A Parts of ASD-STE100

Issue 9, January 2025

STE is a controlled language for technical documentation.
Each approved word has one meaning, so the text is easier to read and to translate.

ASD-STE100
Simplified Technical English

Part 1: 53 writing rules

1 Words
2 Multi-word nouns
3 Verbs
4 Sentences
5 Procedures
6 Descriptive writing
7 Safety instructions
8 Punctuation and word counts
9 Writing practices

Part 2: Dictionary

- Approved words
 Approximately 900
- Words that are not approved
 Approximately 1200, with alternatives
- Technical nouns
 Nouns of your trade (API)
- Technical verbs
 Verbs of your trade (compile)

B Example sentences

annotated examples

Not STE: Prior to commencing the update, it is imperative that all services are shut down.

1 Procedural sentence: the same instruction in STE

8 words, limit 20

Before you start the update, stop all services.

Condition first — Command (imperative) — Technical noun

2 Safety instruction

WARNING: Do not touch the heater. It can burn you.

Risk word — First: a clear command — Then: the risk

WARNING: risk of injury or death

CAUTION: risk of damage to equipment

3 Descriptive sentence

10 words, limit 25

The script stops when the log is larger than 2 GB.

Simple present, active voice — Number and unit: 1 word

C Limits

maximum values

Procedural sentence	max 20 words
Descriptive sentence	max 25 words
Paragraph	max 6 sentences
Multi-word noun	max 3 words
Instructions in a sentence	max 1

Write 2 instructions in 1 sentence only when you do the 2 steps at the same time. Count a number and its unit as 1 word. Also count a hyphenated word and text in parentheses as 1 word. In a vertical list, a colon counts as a full stop.

D Verb forms

Section 3

Form	Example
✓ Imperative (command)	Stop the fan.
✓ Simple present	The fan stops.
✓ Simple past	The fan stopped.
✓ Simple future	The fan will stop.
✓ Infinitive	Use a key to stop it.
✓ Past participle as adjective	the stopped fan
✗ Progressive, perfect	is stopping, has stopped
✗ Passive in an instruction	It must be stopped.
✗ -ing form as a verb	before stopping it

Use the -ing form only in a technical noun, for example "landing gear". In descriptive text, use the passive only when the agent is unknown.

E Dictionary entries

Part 2 format, Issue 9

Word	Meaning or alternative	STE example	Not STE
✓ ABOUT (prep)	Concerned with	This page gives data **about** the API.	Use it only with this meaning
✗ about (adv)	APPROXIMATELY	Wait **approximately** 10 min.	Wait about 10 min.
✗ check (v)	MAKE SURE	**Make sure** that the light is on.	Check that the light is on.
✗ test (v)	TEST (n)	Do a **test** of the alarm.	Test the alarm.
✗ perform (v)	DO	**Do** the steps in this section.	Perform the steps in this section.
✗ describe (v)	GIVE	This section **gives** the steps.	This section describes the steps.
✗ need (v)	NECESSARY (adj)	An admin account is **necessary**.	You need an admin account.
✗ allow (v)	LET	Do not **let** the disk become full.	Do not allow the disk to fill up.
✗ shut down (v)	STOP	**Stop** the server.	Shut down the server.
✗ should (v)	MUST	The PIN **must** have 6 digits.	The PIN should have 6 digits.

UPPERCASE: approved. Lowercase: not approved. An approved word keeps only its approved meaning and part of speech. Technical nouns and verbs are not in the dictionary. Do not use a technical noun as a verb (rule 1.7) or a technical verb as a noun (rule 1.13).

F History and status

asd-ste100.org

1979	1986	2004	2025
Airlines and AECMA start the project	First AECMA guide	New name: ASD-STE100	Issue 9: a standard

ATA iSpec 2200 and directives from EASA, FAA and CAAC make STE mandatory for aircraft manuals. S1000D recommends it. Writers also use STE for defense, vehicles, energy and medical devices. The STEMG schedules Issue 10 for January 2028.

Title
Simplified Technical English: overview

Standard	Owner	
ASD-STE100, Issue 9	ASD, Brussels	
Facts as of: 2026-10-03	Revision: A	Sheet: 1 of 1

Source
asd-ste100.org (the standard is a free PDF)